Now, he was accusing me and other channels of falsifying his remarks on Modi. The fact is, we hadn't distorted Mani's derisive comment. The reference to the 'tea stall' was as direct as it could get. During his election campaign, Modi had often spoken of how he had started life as a young boy selling tea at the railway station in Vadnagar. It was his way of distinguishing himself from the privileged upbringing of the Gandhi family, and in his speeches he projected himself very much as a pulled-up-by-my-own-bootstraps achiever compared with silver spoon-sucking bungalow babies. Now, an elite Congressman, who identified himself completely with the Gandhis, was mocking his tea boy origins. This was too good a chance to miss.

Prime time on the night of Rahul's best public speech should have been dominated by the Congress leader's 'coming of age' moment. Instead, the BJP got an opportunity to hijack the debate by targeting Aiyar's insulting remark about their leader. A new narrative snaked out to cut the ground from under Rahul's feet—Rahul, the *shehzada* (prince) versus Modi, the *chaiwallah* (tea boy). In an aspirational, highly socially competitive India where there is growing rage against elite and entitled privilege and where sensitivities on 'westernized' condescension towards desi mores run high, Mani had just scored another self-goal for his beleaguered party.

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'Where did the idea of "*Chai pe Charcha*" come from?' I asked several BJP strategists. No one gave me a clear answer. 'Good ideas always come from the leader,' a Team Modi member put it diplomatically.

There was a distinct Modi touch to the concept. Right from the time I had first met him during the Ayodhya rath yatra, I could see he was a shrewd event manager. I would often joke in the office, 'If Modi loses the election, we should hire him as our chief marketing officer!' He fancied the idea of branding any occasion that he felt would resonate with the voter. 'Chai pe Charcha' was one such occasion.